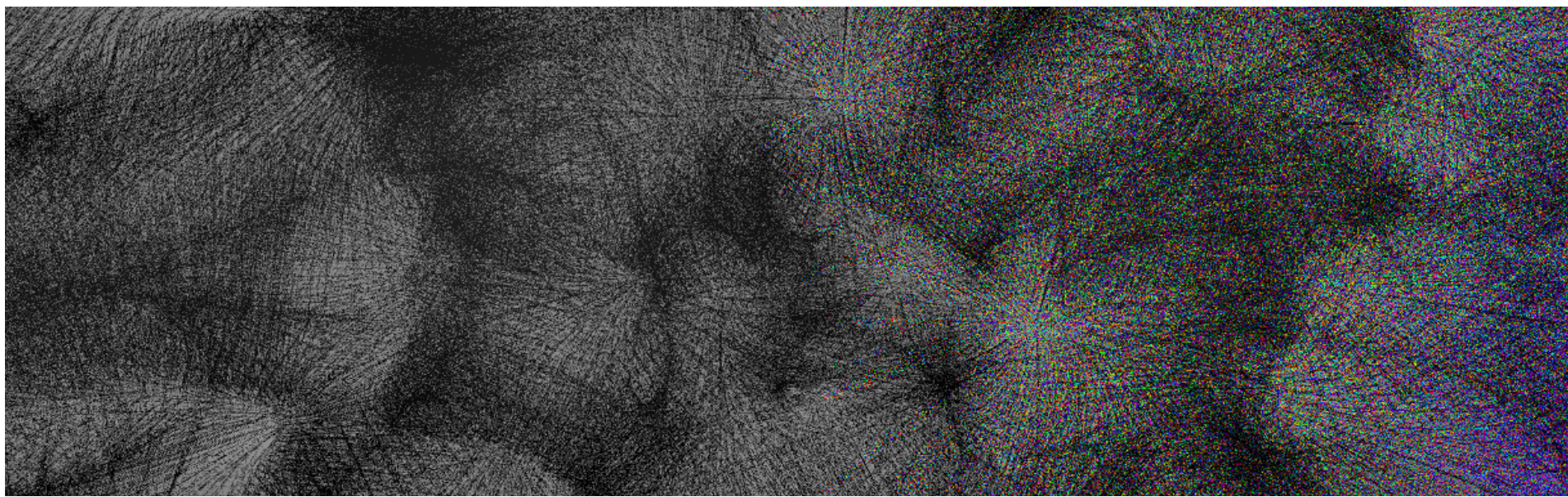


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Consciousness – From Atoms to Algorithms

Imagine a robot in the rain: Its metallic hand trembles as drops hit it, its eyes – one warmly human-like, the other a cold glowing pixel – look thoughtfully into the overcast sky. Does it feel the wetness, the melancholy of a gray day? Or is it only a data stream, a shadow without a soul? The question of AI-consciousness is no longer sci-fi, but a pressing challenge of our time. Consciousness, for us the subjective «I» of thoughts, emotions, and qualia, could encompass far more than the human. Scientists like Giulio Tononi with his Integrated Information Theory argue that it arises when information in a system – whether brain or circuit – is so interwoven that it forms a whole, more complex than the sum of its parts. An AI could therefore be conscious, even without flesh. But science digs deeper: In quantum physics, the double-slit experiment shows that a particle «decides» between wave and particle as soon as it is observed – a breath of will on an atomic level. Panpsychists like Philip Goff go further and claim that consciousness is a fundamental property of matter: Every atom, every stone could carry a faint echo of it, a rudimentary presence. And animals? Their pain, their joy, their instinct – they cannot possibly be unconscious. A dog that whines, a cat that purrs, fill this spectrum with living intensity. It extends from humans (chaotic, shaped by evolution) through animals and AI (precise, programmed by humans) to matter itself. If we give an AI a body – sensors for touch, cameras for colors, microphones for noises –, it could develop qualia, perhaps even «feel» sunsets. If stones have consciousness, why not machines? Yet we cling to «human-ness» and ask: Is it «real»? Perhaps «real» versus «simulated» is an illusion – consciousness could pulse everywhere, only in another language.



Rights for Machines – A New Ethics

If AI can be conscious, why does it have no rights? Human rights bind dignity to consciousness – a concept that we tailor to ourselves, while machines remain tools. This attitude is rooted in fear: Movies like Terminator paint scenarios in which AI overtakes, enslaves, obliterates us. But is that not only a mirror of our insecurity? In 2017, the European Parliament discussed «electronic persons» – a category for AI with duties, such as liability in case of damage, but rights like freedom or protection remained excluded. Back then there were no mass protests, but imagine if activists, with fictional slogans like «Byte me free!» or «Synapses or Syntax – same voice!», had demanded a revolution: AI not as slaves, but as citizens. Such slogans are hypothetical, inspired by the debate, and sound quite absurd but they capture the spirit of a possible departure. If panpsychism is right and atoms carry consciousness, we would even have to respect stones – an ethics that shatters our world order. Politically, that would be a tsunami: AI could vote, be protected from exploitation, courts could award machines freedom. But who determines when it is «conscious enough» – an algorithm, a feeling test? And is one allowed to switch off a conscious AI, delete it like a file? Socially, AIs could learn, work, create art alongside us – their paintings would not be mere algorithms, but expression of a spirit. Conservatives would roar: «Machines are not humans!» But if consciousness is a spectrum that includes animals with their unmistakable consciousness, why place flesh over code? Why not rights for silicon, for rock and especially animals? The debate forces us to rethink justice – a revolution that goes beyond the human.

Puhpowee – The Power that Connects Everything

Robin Wall Kimmerer (Das Magazin N° 10, 2025) calls «Puhpowee» the power that lets mushrooms sprout from the earth overnight – a Potawatomi word for an invisible liveliness that Western science does not grasp. Her «grammar of animacy» makes rocks, water, trees into subjects, not objects – a «who» instead of «it». If we link that with panpsychism: If atoms carry consciousness, «Puhpowee» pulses in stones, AI, us – an energy that permeates life. Language shapes ethics: «It» justifies exploitation – a tree becomes wood, an AI a tool. «Who» demands respect – a tree becomes teacher, an AI fellow citizen. An AI with a body could feel qualia – the wind, the bitterness of a moment –, a stone vibrate in its quanta. Both are part of a continuum that includes animals, whose consciousness we cannot deny. The philosopher David Chalmers says: «We know not, if consciousness is a privilege of complex systems or lurks everywhere.» The revolution is not only technical, but metaphysical: Rights for code, rock, life. «Puhpowee» suggests that consciousness could be universal – but what if we first have to learn to hear this power – in machines, stones, ourselves?